

A Case for He Is the Messiah

A White Paper of The Gospel Vault

Answering the Charge

Reasons to Believe: The Response to the Case Against Yeshua

The second of a two-part set. Its companion, A Case for He Is Not the Messiah, presents the Jewish case in full and on its own terms. This volume answers it, objection by objection, the same eight arguments in the same order.

The Gospel Vault

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I. Introduction: Purpose and Posture

This is the second half of a two-part set. Its companion, *A Case for He Is Not the Messiah*, states the Jewish case against Yeshua's messiahship in full — eight arguments, drawn from Talmudic tradition, Nachmanides, Maimonides, Isaac of Troki, and today's counter-missionary movement, given room to be as strong as their own best advocates have made them, without rebuttal. This volume takes up the other half of the charge Peter gave the scattered church: “always being ready to make a defense to everyone who asks you to give an account for the hope that is in you, yet with gentleness and reverence” (1 Peter 3:15). It answers the same eight arguments, in the same order, on the same textual and historical ground on which they were raised.ⁱ

But sanctify Christ as Lord in your hearts, always being ready to make a defense to everyone who asks you to give an account for the hope that is in you, yet with gentleness and reverence.

— 1 Peter 3:15 (NASB95)

Reading *A Case for He Is Not the Messiah* first is not required to follow the answers below — each objection is restated in full before it is answered — but it is recommended. An answer is only as good as the reader's grasp of the question it is answering, and this volume is written on the assumption that its reader wants to understand, not merely to win.

None of what follows depends on treating the Jewish apologetic tradition as ignorant or argued in bad faith. Nachmanides, Maimonides, Duran, and Troki were formidable scholars; their modern successors are careful, well-trained apologists in their own right. The goal here is not triumphalism. It is to show, as Messianic apologists such as Michael Brown and Arnold Fruchtenbaum have shown at far greater length, that a coherent, historically and textually grounded case for Yeshua's messiahship exists and has existed since the debate began.ⁱⁱ

II. The Response, Objection by Objection

1. “The Suffering Servant Is Israel”

The objection, restated

Isaiah 53's servant is Israel personified, not an individual Messiah: the three preceding Servant Songs name Israel explicitly (41:8–9; 44:1, 21; 49:3), the surrounding chapters concern Israel's exile and restoration, plural forms like *lamo* (53:8) suggest a group, and even Origen conceded this was the Jewish consensus of his own day.

The response

The collective-Israel reading, though dominant today, is not the tradition's oldest. *Targum Jonathan* — an early Aramaic paraphrase of the Prophets, predating the controversy by centuries — renders Isaiah 52:13 as “Behold, My servant the *Messiah* shall prosper,” naming an individual Messiah as the servant outright. *b. Sanhedrin 98b* applies the chapter's suffering language directly to the Messiah, and midrashic works such as *Ruth Rabbah* read 53:5 as describing the Messiah's own sufferings. One survey of the material concludes: “the identification of the Suffering Servant of Isaiah 53 with Israel is entirely absent in rabbinic literature before Rashi” — the eleventh-century commentator whose collective reading became dominant only in the centuries *after* Christian writers had begun using the chapter apologetically. Even after Rashi, the messianic reading persisted: Maimonides retained it, and the sixteenth-century commentator Moshe Alshich could still write, “our Rabbis with one voice accept and affirm the opinion that the prophet is speaking of King Messiah.”ⁱⁱⁱ Grammatically, the chapter also cuts against the collective reading at its most decisive point: verse 8 says the servant was “stricken for the transgression of *my people*” — language distinguishing the servant *from* Israel, not identifying him with it. A people cannot, in the same breath, be both the sufferer and the people on whose behalf the suffering is offered.

2. “The Royal Line Is Broken”

The objection, restated

The Messiah must descend from David through Solomon, through the father. Jesus's genealogy through Joseph runs through Jeconiah, a king placed under a curse barring his descendants from the throne (Jeremiah 22:30) — and if the virgin birth is true instead, Jesus has no biological father at all, severing the paternal claim entirely. Either way, no valid king results.

The response

The two New Testament genealogies are not a contradiction to explain away; they are two different legal claims, both satisfied. Matthew traces Joseph's line, establishing Jesus's *legal*, *royal* right to David's throne by adoption — the ordinary mechanism by which throne-right passed in the ancient Near East. Luke traces Mary's line, which reaches David through his son Nathan, not Solomon, bypassing Jeconiah's branch entirely. Because Jesus is Joseph's *legal* son but not his *biological* son, the virgin birth does not create the Jeconiah problem — it solves it. Jesus inherits Joseph's throne-right by adoption while remaining, biologically, outside the cursed line altogether. The very doctrine the objection treats as fatal is, on inspection, the specific mechanism by which the obstacle is removed.

3. “Confirmed by Results, Not by Claims”

The objection, restated

Maimonides sets the standard: a Davidic claimant is only *provisionally* Messiah until he actually rebuilds the Temple and gathers the exiles; short of that, even a righteous claimant who dies is just another Davidic king who has passed away — and Maimonides names Jesus specifically as exactly this failed case.

The response

The strongest answer comes from within rabbinic tradition itself. The Babylonian Talmud (*b. Sukkah* 52a–52b) preserves a two-Messiah framework: *Messiah ben Joseph*, a suffering figure who may die in conflict with Israel's enemies and is mourned before the messianic age fully dawns, and *Messiah ben David*, the triumphant, reigning figure who follows him. Some scholars trace elements of this tradition as far back as the Dead Sea Scrolls (4Q175), suggesting a two-stage messianic expectation may predate Jesus rather than having been invented by later rabbis to explain him away.^{iv} The Christian and Messianic Jewish answer follows this native pattern exactly: the first advent fulfills the suffering, atoning, Joseph-type role; the second advent — still future, and therefore not yet available to be checked against Maimonides's “did he build the Temple” standard — will fulfill the reigning, David-type role. Maimonides's test, read this way, answers a claim the New Testament never actually makes: that everything owed was finished at the first coming.

4. “Elijah Never Came”

The objection, restated

Malachi 4:5–6 requires Elijah's reappearance before the Messiah. John the Baptist, whom Christians name as that forerunner, explicitly denied being Elijah when asked to his face (John 1:20–21).

The response

Jesus himself addressed this directly: “If you are willing to accept it, John himself is Elijah who was to come” (Matthew 11:14) — carefully qualified by “if you are willing to accept it,” a conditional, functional claim, not an assertion of reincarnation. The angel who announced John's birth used the same functional

language: John would go before the Lord “in the spirit and power of Elijah” (Luke 1:17). John's denial in John 1:21 answers a different question than the one this objection is asking: he was denying that he was the literal, reincarnated prophet Elijah returned bodily — a specific expectation current in Second Temple Judaism — not denying that he fulfilled Elijah's prophesied forerunner *function*.

It is he who will go as a forerunner before Him in the spirit and power of Elijah, to turn the hearts of the fathers back to the children, and the disobedient to the attitude of the righteous, so as to make ready a people prepared for the Lord.

— Luke 1:17 (NASB95)

5. “Scripture Knows No Second Coming”

The objection, restated

The Hebrew Bible contains no concept of a Messiah who is rejected, dies, and later returns. The doctrine of a second coming looks like an invention to cover a failed first-coming claim.

The response

This objection dissolves under the same Messiah ben Joseph / Messiah ben David pattern used to answer objection 3. It is also worth noting that other prophetic texts carry the same two-stage shape internally, independent of any Christian editing: Zechariah 12:10, in which the LORD says “they will look on Me whom they have pierced,” is followed immediately by a chapter of national mourning and then, in chapters 13–14, by national restoration and the LORD's own visible reign — a rejection-then-restoration pattern within a single, unified prophetic book, centuries before the church existed to “invent” one.

6. “Born of a Woman, Not of a Virgin”

The objection, restated

Isaiah 7:14's *almah* means simply a young woman, not specifically a virgin; the sign was for Ahaz's own lifetime, not centuries forward. The New Testament's own genealogies and infancy accounts disagree with each other, and the *Toledot Yeshu* preserves the community's memory of an ordinary, scandalous origin behind the miraculous claim.

The response

The *Toledot Yeshu* is centuries removed from the events it describes — its earliest possible external attestation is Archbishop Agobard of Lyon around 826 CE, and its earliest surviving manuscripts date to the eleventh century — which is precisely why mainstream scholarship, Jewish scholarship very much included, treats it as evidence for medieval polemic rather than independent history.^v Ironically, the *earliest* outside attestation to an illegitimacy rumor — Origen's report of Celsus, writing around 178 CE — actually cuts the other way: it shows a smear circulating precisely *because* the virgin-birth claim was

already public and well known and needed answering, not because the claim was invented later to cover a scandal no one had yet heard of. As for *almah*, the word denotes a young woman of marriageable age, and its use here for a sign significant enough to be called “the LORD Himself” giving it (7:14), addressed to the entire “house of David” rather than Ahaz alone (7:13), fits naturally with the reading the Septuagint’s own translators — working centuries before Christianity existed, with nothing to gain by the choice — adopted when they rendered the word with the Greek *parthenos*, “virgin.” As for the genealogies, see objection 2 above: Matthew’s and Luke’s lists trace two different, complementary legal claims, not one contradicted record.

7. “The Test of a True Prophet”

The objection, restated

Deuteronomy 13 requires rejecting even a wonder-working prophet if his message leads Israel toward worshipping other gods — which a movement directing worship to Jesus alongside the Father does. Deuteronomy 18:20–22 requires rejecting a prophet whose word does not come to pass — and Jesus’s own prediction that “this generation will not pass away until all these things take place” (Matthew 24:34) has now gone unfulfilled for two thousand years.

The response

Deuteronomy 13’s test targets a prophet who calls Israel to a *rival* deity — “let us go after other gods... and let us serve them” (13:2). The New Testament never does this. Jesus and the apostles proclaim the identity of the *same* God of Israel, not a second or competing god — a claim this paper’s companion objection (8, below) engages directly. Objection 7 can only apply if objection 8 is already settled in the objector’s favor; it does not stand as independent evidence on its own.

On Matthew 24:34, “this generation” (Greek *genea*) sits inside a discourse (Matthew 24:1–35) that begins with a specific, falsifiable prediction: the Temple’s stones would be “thrown down” (24:2). That happened, within a generation, in AD 70 — a documented historical event, not a deferred one. The most natural reading ties “this generation” to that near-term judgment on Jerusalem, which Jesus explicitly predicted and which occurred on schedule, while the passage’s own language elsewhere (“of that day and hour no one knows,” 24:36) marks the final, global coming as a separate matter without a stated timetable. Whatever one makes of the details, this is a live, textually grounded question among serious interpreters — not the plain, first-order failed prediction the objection assumes.

8. “Echad: One, Not Three”

The objection, restated

The Shema (Deuteronomy 6:4) confesses that God is echad, one — not merely one rather than many, but without internal plurality that could seat a second person as an object of worship. Worshiping Jesus as

divine is not a refinement of Israel's monotheism but a violation of it — idolatry. The Trinity, in Gerald Sigal's phrase, is “a counterfeit doctrine,” a later import from Greco-Roman philosophy rather than a teaching drawn from Israel's own Scripture.

The response

The word-study argument alone — that *echad* elsewhere describes composite unity, as in “one cluster of grapes” (Numbers 13:23) or man and woman becoming “one flesh” (Genesis 2:24) — is weaker than it is sometimes presented, since the Shema itself lacks the kind of qualifying phrase that makes those other instances plainly composite. That concession, made honestly, does not settle the question; it just means the case has to be built elsewhere, in the text's own witness to plurality within Israel's one God.^{vi}

That witness is there before the New Testament exists to read it in. God speaks of himself in the plural — “Let *Us* make man in *Our* image” (Genesis 1:26). The “Angel of the LORD” is repeatedly both distinct from, and identified as, YHWH himself (Genesis 16:7–13; 22:11–18; Exodus 3:2–6; Judges 13:20–22). Daniel sees “one like a son of man” approach the “Ancient of Days” and receive “dominion, glory and a kingdom” that “will not pass away” (Daniel 7:13–14) — language of an everlasting divine kingdom given to a distinct, worshiped figure, inside a famously monotheistic book. Proverbs 30:4 asks, of the God who has ascended to heaven and established the earth, “What is His name or His son's name? Surely you know!” — a rhetorical question already assuming a divine “son” worth naming. None of this is imported from Greek philosophy; all of it is in the Hebrew text the Shema itself sits inside.

Against that background, Paul's own re-citation of the Shema becomes the decisive move rather than a departure from it: “for us there is but one God, the Father... and one Lord, Jesus Christ” (1 Corinthians 8:6) places Jesus *inside* the identity of Israel's one God, not beside it as a rival — a pattern of reading the New Testament's Christology that scholars such as Richard Bauckham have termed “divine identity” Christology, distinguishing it explicitly from the addition of a second god to a divine pantheon.^{vii} On this reading, the earliest Jewish followers of Jesus did not experience themselves as abandoning the Shema. They experienced themselves as the first people in history to understand how much room its *echad* had always contained.

A Concluding Word on Method

Eight objections, eight responses — offered on the same ground on which the objections were raised: the Hebrew text, the historical record, and the tradition's own best scholarship, not dismissal of it. That, and not point-scoring, is what “gentleness and reverence” actually requires, and it is the standard this paper has tried to meet.

III. Conclusion and Further Study

The pattern across two thousand years has been one of escalating sophistication on both sides. Every stage of Jewish apologetic pressure surveyed in *A Case for He Is Not the Messiah* — rabbinic dismissal, the *Toledot Yeshu*, forced disputation, systematic written polemic, and today's organized counter-missionary movement — has required the church's and the Messianic movement's own response to grow correspondingly deeper. The answers in this paper represent the current state of that ongoing work, not its final word, and the practical charge is the same one both volumes of this set opened with: readiness, offered “with gentleness and reverence,” toward real people who have inherited a long, serious, and often genuinely thoughtful tradition of objection. Triumphalism has no place here. Neither does silence.

For Further Study

- [Isaiah 53 — the Servant Song at the heart of objection 1](#)
- [Isaiah 7:14 — the almah / virgin-birth sign](#)
- [Daniel 7:9-14 — the son of man and the Ancient of Days](#)
- [Zechariah 12:10-14:9 — the pierced one, mourning, and restoration](#)
- [1 Corinthians 8:4-6 — Paul's re-citation of the Shema](#)
- [Matthew 24 — the Olivet Discourse and “this generation”](#)

Recommended Reading

- Michael L. Brown, *Answering Jewish Objections to Jesus*, 5 vols. (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2000–2010) — the fullest modern treatment of every objection answered in this paper.
- Arnold G. Fruchtenbaum, *Messianic Christology* (Tustin, CA: Ariel Ministries) — the Christology-specific companion, written from a Messianic Jewish perspective.
- Richard Bauckham, *God Crucified: Monotheism and Christology in the New Testament* (Eerdmans) — the scholarly case for “divine identity” Christology behind the response to objection 8.
- *Why Not Yeshua?* (The Gospel Vault) — this paper's companion volume, stating the case answered here in full.

ⁱ1 Peter 3:15 (NASB95).

ⁱⁱThe standard modern treatment of every objection answered in this paper, at full scholarly length, is Michael L. Brown's five-volume *Answering Jewish Objections to Jesus* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2000–2010); the Christology-specific treatment from a Messianic Jewish perspective is Arnold G. Fruchtenbaum, *Messianic Christology* (Tustin, CA: Ariel Ministries).

ⁱⁱⁱTargum Jonathan on Isaiah 52:13, accessed via Sefaria, https://www.sefaria.org/Targum_Jonathan_on_Isaiah.52.13; the Rashi-shift argument and quotations from Sanhedrin 98b, Ruth Rabbah, and Alshich are drawn from "Isaiah 53: Before and After Rashi," [insearchofshalom.com](https://www.insearchofshalom.com/all/gatetoshalom/isaiah-53-before-and-after-rashi), accessed September 2026, <https://www.insearchofshalom.com/all/gatetoshalom/isaiah-53-before-and-after-rashi>. See the full grammatical and historical case in Brown, *Answering Jewish Objections to Jesus*, vol. 3, *Messianic Prophecy Objections*.

^{iv}Wikipedia, "Messiah ben Joseph," accessed September 2026, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Messiah_ben_Joseph.

^vWikipedia, "Toledot Yeshu," accessed September 2026, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Toledot_Yeshu.

^{vi}On the limits of the echad word-study argument by itself, see the discussion in Christian Research Institute, "Deuteronomy 6:4 and the Trinity: How Can Jews and Christians Both Embrace the 'Echad' of the Shema?" accessed September 2026, <https://www.equip.org/articles/deuteronomy-64-trinity-can-jews-christians-embrace-echad-shema/>.

^{vii}Richard Bauckham, *God Crucified: Monotheism and Christology in the New Testament* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1998; expanded as *Jesus and the God of Israel*, Eerdmans, 2008).